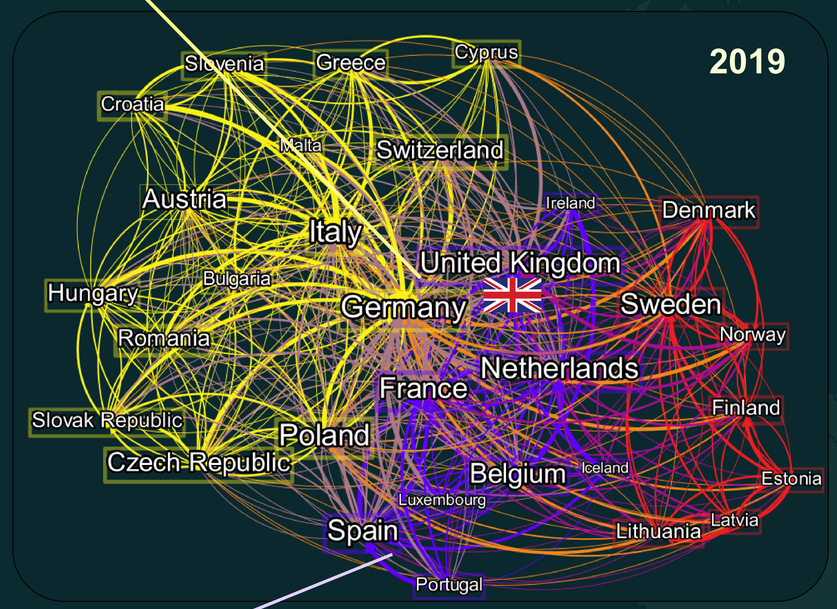
FROM UNITY TO FRAGMENTATION? A NETWORK ANALYSIS OF UK - EU/EFTA TRADE (2019 - 2022)

During the 2019 - 2022 period, the world economy was shaken by a series of major events - Covid-19, Brexit, soaring inflation, global recession fears, and the Russia-Ukraine war. According to GOV.UK (2025), "UK trade statistics saw higher levels of volatility between 2019 and 2022". This poster explores the evolving trade network between the UK and EU/EFTA countries, analysing network snapshots from 2019 and 2022. Goods trade was particularly impacted more compared to services, prompting this poster's focus on goods trade. The analysis reveals the European trade network remains structurally strong despite global disruptions. However, clearer regional groupings in 2022 network suggests a boom in regional cohesiveness, with the UK stepping back from its former central role.

Located centrally, acting as bridges across clusters.

UK, France, Germany

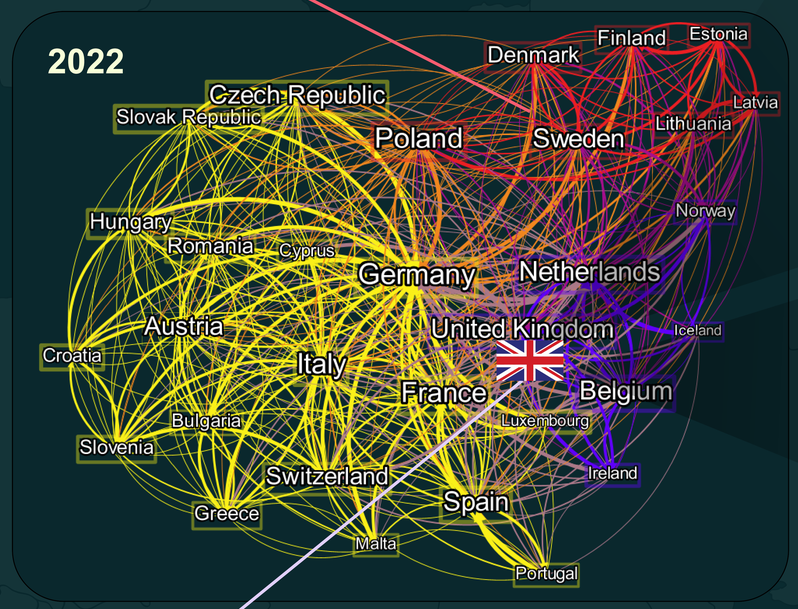


Spain and Portugal

Are clustered further away from Italy and Greece.

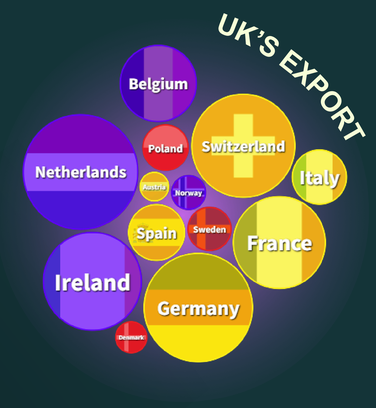
Intra-regional ties strengthen as nodes draw closer together.

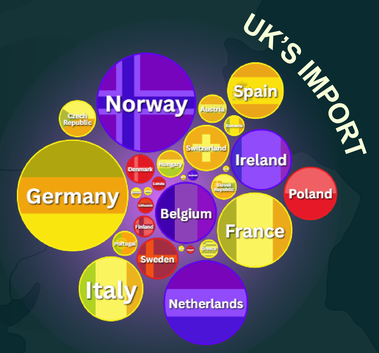
Nordics & Baltics



The UK

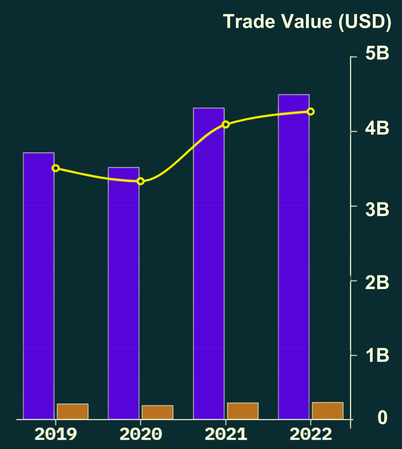
Slight peripheral shift, though still connected to key players. Hinting mild regional re-fragmentation in 2022.





VISUAL KEY

Colour	Modularity class
Node's label size	Number of connections
Edge Weight	Percent of the Country's total Exports

METRIC	2019	2022
Nodes/Edges	31/468	31/465
Weighted Degree	31.65	31.13
Diameter	3	4
Modularity	0.138	0.131

The bar graphs illustrate the amount of The UK's **Imports** and **Exports** with EU/EFTA countries, along with resulting **Trade deficit**. There was a noticeable shift in UK imports, it dropped in 2020 but rebounded significantly in 2021 and 2022. Exports followed a similar trend, though the changes were less pronounced. Regarding the Trade deficit, after the 2020 dip, the deficit worsened significantly.